

## CHAPTER 10

# Domestic Cooks' Work toward Moroccan *Beldi* Foods in Uncertain Times

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### Introduction

I was about to finish writing fieldnotes in my room on the first floor when I heard someone shuffle across the courtyard of the *riad* (house arranged around a courtyard). The house was otherwise quiet. I decided to have a look. Fatimzahra rested or prayed in her room, but Hajja's door was ajar, her room empty.<sup>1</sup> I found her sitting on the ground in front of a big suitcase in the small *khazin* (storage room). Around her lay jars, plastic boxes, and bags filled with food: olives, spices, dates, coffee, apples, preserved lemons, and more items that I could not identify. I asked Hajja what she was doing, and she began to explain that these foods would be traveling with her to Mecca the following week for the hajj (pilgrimage around the time of 'Id el-kebir, one of the five obligations or pillars of Islam). She listed each item, lifting them visibly for me, then repackaged them for the journey. When she lifted the box with the small preserved lemons, she paused, looked intently at me, and explained, "These are *beldi* lemons."

I had not heard the term *beldi* with respect to food before and enquired. Hajja explained that these are lemons from Taroudant, her *bled* (hometown or village) in the Souss Valley, south of the city of Marrakesh. Usually a woman of few words and gestures, she grew animated as she told me about the lemon trees on her inherited family land: her siblings tended lemon and olive trees for her and sent her a share of the harvest each year, along with other *beldi* food products. She packed them, because she had to have a "taste of home" (*legout dyel bled*) on that month-long journey to Mecca. To make her point and show me another *beldi* product, she lifted the dried black olives that she had packed already. She continued to explain her motivation for every item in the suitcase; many foods were not *beldi*, but she took them because she preferred their familiar taste and

quality: “During the hajj I have to eat well, it will be tiring. In Mecca the food is expensive and bad, they sell *whatever* to all the pilgrims. ... I know from my last trip to Mecca for the ‘*omra* [the so-called small pilgrimage, carried out during the rest of the Islamic calendar].”

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This first encounter with *beldi* foods took place in a very intimate and personal moment, a moment that I could have easily missed. Hajja did not think that this was interesting for my research, yet she evidently cared deeply about some of the foods she processed and packed for her imminent journey. They would keep her tethered to home and strengthen her while traveling to a faraway place; a journey she did not expect to return from.<sup>2</sup> On that day I began to learn how low-income urban Moroccans think, talk, and feel about the connections between food, taste, and place in the context of movement over space and time. While *beldi* is a universal concept to make sense of the taste and place of people and objects across Morocco, definitions of *beldi* foods are situated and differ for every person depending on where they were born and grew up as well as where they temporarily moved and traveled to.

The notion of *beldi* has very practical implications with respect to food. In the absence of reliable quality standards within the national food system, urban Moroccans like Hajja indicate the provenance and taste of food through the notion of *beldi*. *Beldi* (literally of/from the country) denotes food from one's place of origin but also homemade or artisanal food products, and helps low-income cooks to determine food quality from multiple angles. Although geographical origin labels do exist in Morocco, they target foreign markets and are unaffordable for most low-income consumers.<sup>3</sup> Quite like *domaće* ham in Istria (Colquhoun, this volume), real *beldi* food cannot be purchased in a supermarket. As an analytic tool, *beldi* helps us to note the embodied and intimate perspectives of low-income urban Moroccans around the connections between food, place, and taste; a perspective that is often missing from scholarship that still tends to define the “taste of place” in terms of the notion of terroir.

The vignette also points to another crucial dimension of *beldi* foods. For a food product to be considered *beldi*, a lot of invisible knowledge and work is required, from the maintenance of agricultural land and of family connections to planning, processing, preserving, preparing, and (not) serving it. Importantly, this work is not limited to food producers or middlemen; indeed, domestic cooks, usually women, are central to making foods *beldi* and thus good, as Sanders and Simpson Miller (both this volume) show in similar domestic contexts. It is this largely hidden, gendered knowledge and work of indexing and making *beldi* foods in urban contexts that this chapter focuses on. It argues that the place and taste of food are not only produced by food producers, distributors,

marketers, or governments but also by domestic cooks, in particular low-income women. Moreover, in the broader context of poverty and economic and environmental decline across Morocco, writing about *beldi* grounds discussions “beyond terroir” in existential debates about food security and the desire to create a sense of certainty in everyday life.

I do so through Hajja’s and her daughter Fatimzahra’s practices of tasting and placing foods. The thoughts, practices, and feelings invested in *beldi* foods connect them—each a little differently—to the taste and place of their past, their present, and their future. Though idiosyncratic, their experiences and perspectives are also representative of how low-income Moroccans think about and do food, place, and taste, and help us to shed light on the largely hidden domestic work that particularly poor women carry out every day to ensure that the food they provision, prepare, and serve their families is good in a context of latent food insecurity, a perspective that is still missing from accounts focused on terroir in its commoditized forms (e.g., Trubek 2008; Paxson 2013; West 2022). Analyzing how *beldi* foods are produced in this context thus contributes to widening our understanding of the way people meaningfully taste and place foods in order to recreate an intimate, everyday sense of security and control.

For low-income cooks, taste and place—captured in the notion of *beldi*—are important markers of food quality for three connected reasons, which also structure the main part of the chapter. First, *beldi* orients Moroccans in the context of an ever-faster globalizing food market. Second, as an everyday practice based on intimate bodily knowledge, it provides a material and symbolic sense of certainty in the context of movement over space and time. Yet, third, the making of *beldi* foods is simultaneously marked by an acutely felt erosion of livelihoods and a sense of loss of control. While I will introduce, describe, and analyze these dimensions of *beldi* in the three main sections through Hajja’s and Fatimzahra’s stories, the last point constitutes the core argument of the chapter and moves the debate most obviously “beyond terroir.” I will show not only that domestic cooks, via their knowledgeable food practices, are an important group of people who each cultivate and maintain a very intimate taste of place in today’s fast-moving world; I will also show how their increasing difficulties of doing so situates urban inhabitants of low income in the broader context of change of a globalizing Moroccan food market that systematically undermines domestic food security.

## Studying *Beldi* Practices

*Beldi* begins with individual people, and so does my methodology. Between September and December 2012 I lived and worked with Hajja and her family as part of a year-long apprenticeship to three different domestic Marrakshi cooks.<sup>4</sup> Between 2016 and 2018 I complemented this fieldwork with ethnographic research

with fifteen other low-income families in the cities of Marrakesh and Beni Mellal during a research project on bread (Graf 2024). As opposed to more formalized craft work, the preparation of food is deeply entangled with other daily practices and its apprenticeship much less circumscribed. My methodological approach to studying and learning food preparation, especially my encounter with *beldi* foods, is more aptly described as “participant perception” (Graf 2024): a deeply immersive and multisensory way of participating in everyday life, which embraces the gaps that necessarily accompany such an experienced-based method. Thus, it was often in moments when I was just by chance dipping in and out of food-related activities, in quiet moments as described in the vignette, or in situations where I was tasked with another food-related chore that I encountered *beldi* foods and practices. Indeed, as an embodied and intimate category for foods, people, and places, most of my research participants did not talk much about *beldi* foods; to notice them, I had to learn to perceive their existence and spatial movements through my own multisensory immersion in these women’s everyday lives.

Compared to the other families I worked with, Hajja’s was slightly better off. Hajja moved to Marrakesh as an underage bride in the mid-1960s and was widowed in the early 2000s. In 2012 only one of her five adult children, Hassan, had a steady wage as a low-income but respectable government employee. Although Hassan fully financed her household, which at the time included herself and her two oldest adult children, Fatimzahra and Mohamed, he mostly lived in his own studio flat in a lower-middle-class suburb of Marrakesh. Like most other low-income families who are not destitute, Hajja and her family would not describe themselves as poor. Indeed, when her husband was still alive, her family fared much better, as the fading beauty of their *riad* in the *medina* (historic city center) testified.<sup>5</sup> Hajja’s husband was a local notable (*sheriff*) and once a respected figure in the neighborhood. She often reminisced about the early days of their marriage when they hosted lavish meals featuring high-priced Soussi specialties like saffron or argan oil. However, alcohol addiction and poor health contributed to the decline of his car mechanic business and eventually caused his death. He left the family with debts and in perpetual financial insecurity. It is largely thanks to Hajja’s origins that the family commanded a vast network of kin relations across Morocco and the diaspora, and thus a stronger social security net than many other families I know. Still, their life stories reflect the socioeconomic and environmental decline that other Moroccans I talked to experienced over the last couple of decades.

### ***Beldi* and *Rumi* Foods in a Globalizing Market**

To understand the importance of *beldi* as an embodied index of quality, it is necessary to contextualize *beldi* foods in the contemporary Moroccan food system. In the open-air *sug* (market) that most low-income Moroccans frequent for their

daily food needs, quality is often unpredictable and unreliable. Except for meat and dairy products, most fresh foods in the domestic market are not subject to any control or national standards (Codron et al. 2004; Amine and Lazzaoui 2011). To the contrary, foods that do not pass the strict quality control in the packing stations for exportation to the European Union or the United States end up on the domestic market (Sippel 2014). For example, Hajja's *bled*, the Souss, is one of the most prominent agricultural regions of Morocco, yet roughly half of the vast amount of fresh fruits and vegetables destined for export do not pass the quality tests; instead, these lower-quality products are sold unlabeled in domestic markets (Sippel 2014: 102). The same happens with respect to seasonality: Morocco produces fresh products like tomatoes or strawberries for the EU market during its offseason. As soon as European producers can supply again, the Moroccan products are no longer admitted to the EU and instead flood the domestic market, pushing down domestic prices and threatening the livelihoods of smaller-scale producers (Boeckler and Berndt 2014). In addition, rainfall and seasonality or transport problems affect the availability and quality of everyday food items. Low-income urban Moroccans are well aware of how these factors impact price and quality (Graf 2015).

Together with its counterpart *rumi*, which means “foreign” and might date back to Byzantine times (*rumi* meaning Roman or Christian, referencing Roman colonialism in Morocco some two thousand years ago), *beldi* slots into this (willful) gap of regulation. It is precisely because it is difficult to define exactly what *beldi* and *rumi* mean, and if and how a product can be labeled one or the other, that the pair is such a useful index in this unregulated context. From an urban perspective, according to ethnobotanist Mohamed el Haouz, there are three regular features of *beldi* foods.<sup>6</sup> First, *beldi* and *rumi* denote origin or provenance, including the specific “ecology of production” (Paxson 2013; West 2013) from the perspective of the speaker. *Beldi* means quite literally from one's village, hometown, or region with no or few middlemen involved in its provision. At the very least, *beldi* indexes foods “from Morocco.” *Rumi* indexes food products from another region, from a long supply chain, imported from abroad or simply store bought. Second, the pair indicates mode of production. *Beldi* refers to homemade, artisanal, smallholder, or handmade food production, whereas *rumi* refers to industrial, highly mechanized production or processed foods. Finally, *beldi* denotes a strong or particular taste or flavor, and *rumi* refers to a bland or mild flavor. This includes texture; *beldi* indexes a chewy, crumbly, or less pleasing texture, and *rumi* a smooth, homogenous, and pleasing one.

Despite these fairly widespread features, their meanings and uses vary according to material and social context. In fact, research around *beldi/rumi* produces different results depending on where and with whom the research took place (see, e.g., Sarter 2004; Simenel 2010; Zirari 2020; Jonas 2023).<sup>7</sup> Also, as the features of taste and texture highlight, *beldi* does not always index good food, and *rumi*

does not automatically mean bad food. Furthermore, not all *beldi* foods embody all three features at once, nor does a *beldi* product always have a *rumi* counterpart (or vice versa). Yet Hajja's *beldi* lemons and olives do: they were produced on her native family's land with artisanal methods, sent to her by her relatives, and she processed and preserved them by hand, as a result of which they developed the favored strong, salty umami flavor. In December 2012 I was able to accompany Hajja on a visit to her hometown, a village in the suburbs of the Souss capital Taroudant. Her relatives showed me around their small farms and fields, some under cultivation, many not due to recurrent drought and lack of investment (figure 10.1).

Importantly, this case reveals that a *beldi* mode of production is not limited to agricultural processes in the rural hinterlands. It includes the domestic production of *beldi* in a connected urban context. In search of a more comfortable life and education for their children, not only Hajja but most of my female research participants in Marrakesh and Beni Mellal had migrated from their native *bled* and continued to cultivate their taste of *beldi* foods away from it (see also Meneley, this volume). In case of a lack of connections due to estrangement, or a lack of foods due to a bad harvest, the next best substitute *beldi* foods could come from the broader native region, the wholesale market in the city or even bought from a shopkeeper so long as he hailed from one's native *bled*. Importantly, through their continuous work to provision, process, and prepare *beldi* foods, migrants reproduced their knowledge and their symbolic connections to the *bled*. This knowledge and work are highly gendered and decidedly lower class. While the knowledge of origin and provenance of foods, of regional ecologies,



**Figure 10.1.** Lemon and olive trees on the family's land. Morocco, 2012. © Katharina Graf

yearly variations in harvest, changing prices, and the work of maintaining rural kinship ties even decades after migrating to the city is shared equally among low-income men and women, the knowledge and work of processing, preserving, storing, and preparing food in a *beldi* way is predominantly female.

## Making *Beldi* Foods in Low-Income Homes

Since Hajja returned from the hajj in mid-November the *riad* was always full. Family members from all over Morocco but especially from Hajja's *bled* honored the newly minted Hajja (honorary name given to returnees from the hajj) with their visit. While every visiting party brought food and drinks as is customary—usually industrially produced sugar cones, milk, coffee, tea, or fresh fruits—as hosts we also prepared lots of meals. My role during that month-long celebration was to shop and process foods. I was not surprised when I saw several new bags of food in the *khazin* one day, which Hajja kept locked with a key that she never took off her necklace. This time, however, Fatimzahra was busying herself in the storage room, getting flour for homemade bread. Upon my enquiry she highlighted that this flour was not your average flour, it was twenty kilograms of *beldi* flour, brought by one of their visiting relatives. Receiving this kind of flour was a rare treat these days, I was told, as were all the other *beldi* products I then spotted: clementine, lemons, and several liters of raw milk. Fatimzahra explained that reduced and unpredictable rainfall as well as decreasing groundwater tables seriously threatened their family's smallholder farming (see also Sippel 2014).

At night on that same day, when temperatures hovered just above zero degree Celsius, I came back to the *riad* from a meeting with a friend when I heard Fatimzahra's electric blender from the not-much-warmer kitchen. I found her in the middle of processing the raw milk I had spotted earlier: with her right hand she held onto the top of her blender, with her left hand she operated the switch, to her right was a casserole filled with something that looked like clotted milk, to her left was a bottle half filled with buttermilk (*lben*) and turned upside down on top of a small bowl and a sieve, yet another white liquid slowly dripped from the bottle into the bowl. When I asked her what she was doing, Fatimzahra pulled out a plate with three little yellow lumps of butter from behind her, "I'm making butter." She explained that it was too cold, and thus the blender had to work harder to churn the milk. She repeatedly switched it on and off because it got too hot; indeed, it smelled of burning plastic.

Finally, she tapped the blender, muttering "poor thing", and decided to clean up and filter the remaining milk through a sieve and into another bottle, entertaining the hope to find some more lumps of butter layered on top in the morning. Nearly finished, Fatimzahra pointed to the casserole with the liquid and introduced it as *ghaib*, a drinkable yoghurt to which she planned to add sugar

later. She confessed with a deeply satisfied smile that she had already drank quite a bit of it. It was the first time she seemed genuinely happy and satisfied during these hard-working days following Hajja's return from Mecca. As she walked out of the cold kitchen to go to sleep, she concluded our conversation: "*Beldi* [here meaning homemade] food is simply the best. You know what's in there!" She gestured toward her tummy, rubbed it, and sighed with pleasure. For her, this was food as good as it gets.

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Although I had spent nearly one hour with her in the kitchen—and had been sharing meals with her and her family for a couple of months already—I was not offered a taste of any of these raw milk products. This was Fatimzahra's very own moment of pleasure, and she had worked toward it. In her case, making *beldi* foods as in this vignette gave her back her agency and sense of being in control of her body and life, both with respect to her subordinate role within the domestic division of labor vis-à-vis her mother and with respect to her inability to purchase more high-priced foods generally deemed healthy, such as fruits or fish. In Hajja's case *beldi* was often oriented toward her past and the life she left behind. Although she often told me about her own practices of hand-rolling couscous grains, ensuring a "better" taste in the resulting dish, she was also adamant that she had "worked much harder back then" and didn't miss this work at all. Most of the times, though, she invoked the *bled* as "her" place marking her roots (*ʿasl*), her family and land. In the case of her suitcase full of *beldi* foods, Hajja oriented *beldi* toward the future, to the imminent travel as well as her afterlife. Provisioning foods in the *bled* and making *beldi* foods enabled her to reenact her material and symbolic roots and feel a sense of certainty and control in moments of vulnerability, from being a young bride moving to the big city to that of a pilgrim traveling to a holy but unsafe place.

It is important to note that although *beldi* foods were often more expensive, more difficult to provision, and required more work than their *rumi* variants, most cooks carefully considered the trade-offs and often deemed the additional efforts worth it. That real *beldi* products can only be truly cherished by oneself and usually only a handful of other people highlights the immense value that most low-income Moroccans ascribe to it. Thus, rather than indexing simply good or bad foods, the pair has to be understood as a situated and embodied way to define and, crucially, "make" foods good, and doing so allows low-income Moroccans like Hajja and Fatimzahra to create an everyday sense of control in a world of flux.

In other words, the categories depend on context and bodily knowledge; *beldi* does not mean the same thing for everyone and cannot be made by and for everyone. In fact, most middle- and upper-class urban Moroccans would associate





Figure 10.2. Packaged *beldi* bread sold in a supermarket. Morocco, 2017. © Katharina Graf

*beldi* with a certain rural backwardness and *rumi* with modernity and cosmopolitanism. Notions of “us” and “them” are locating differences across income and class. Rachik’s (1997) description of *beldi* and *rumi* furniture and fashion in middle- and upper-income urban homes is suggestive. Whereas low tables and cushions are described as *beldi* or Moroccan, high tables and chairs are described as *rumi* or European. The former tends to be associated with working-class taste, the latter with middle-class tastes and lifestyles.<sup>8</sup> Montgomery (2016) describes a similar association with regards to Moroccan and European dishes: while European or *rumi* dishes such as vegetable creams or pastas are considered to be urban and modern, *beldi* dishes such as meat stews or legume soups are associated with rural foodways and tradition.

At the same time, educated urban professionals who are well versed in European discourses surrounding what Grasseni (2016) calls the “heritage arena” are now “reinventing” (West 2013, Grasseni and Paxson 2014) *beldi* as a Moroccan version of organic (Jazi 2014) or terroir foods (Jonas 2023). The occasional surfacing of labeled *beldi* products in supermarkets, which largely target middle- and upper-income Moroccans, is indicative of this reinvention (figure 10.2; see also Graf 2018). While my low-income research participants, urban inhabitants themselves, were well aware of the above-described derogative meanings of *beldi* and generally refrained from using *beldi* or *rumi* to describe people or index “us”

versus “them,” they were also disinterested in recent reinventions of *beldi* as an equivalent to organic or local foods. None of my research participants described *beldi* as “organic” or “local.”

To the contrary, for my research participants—most of them migrants with rural roots—*beldi* foods materialized and represented a very intimate taste of place that exceeds simplified associations of *beldi* as lower class and resists commodification. The embodied qualities of *beldi* foods may simply be lost to others. As stated above, the products that Fatimzahra produced with the raw milk from her mother’s *bled* were not offered to me or any of our visitors. Making and consuming them was as intimate as the notion of *beldi* itself; it was a very personal pleasure crucial to Hajja’s and Fatimzahra’s sense of security. Outside of certain bodies, certain *beldi* products simply do not make sense. For them, and for countless other low-income Moroccans working to make *beldi* foods every day, *beldi* is not a fixed category or a marketable product but rather a bundle of everyday practices that enable them to locate themselves and others in time and space through tasting and placing foods. The fact that this work was often taking place in quiet and private moments, hidden from others, and that I stumbled upon it by chance rather than being introduced to it more explicitly is indicative of this.

In sum, foods acquire their *beldiness*, that is, their taste and their place, which indicate their goodness, through domestic cooks’ knowledge and work. This work begins with the upkeep of social and material relations to the homeland. Regular visits; frequent phone calls about sowing, tending, or harvesting foods on the family land; processing knowledge such as that of preserving lemons or making butter; as well as enacting mutual hospitality are the centerpieces of this work. This work testifies that low-income domestic cooks like them did not assume that food is intrinsically good; it had to be made good. These nuanced meanings and practices associated with *beldi* and *rumi* more generally point to the complex moral economies surrounding Moroccan notions of “us” and “them,” traditional and modern or local and global. The pair is contrasting but not necessarily dichotomous, while always being situational and context specific. It is these features of tasting and placing foods and people—including themselves—and the fact that they can be actively made that gives my research participants their sense of security and control in the context of rapid change. So what happens if making *beldi* foods is becoming more difficult?

### ***Beldi* Foods in the Context of Decline**

With the beginning of the olive harvest in late November, Fatimzahra was regularly on the phone speaking to aunts and cousins, later to acquaintances from other parts of Morocco. She tried to assure a supply of unprocessed olives from the Souss but did not succeed. The trees of her mother’s family did not carry any



**Figure 10.3.** Unused olive press. Morocco, 2012. © Katharina Graf

olives that year, a fact that we confirmed in person during the December visit to the countryside. Indeed, the two olive presses on her family land had remained unused for years, because the harvest had gradually declined to insignificant quantities (figure 10.3). Fatimzahra involved her entire social network to access unprocessed olives to turn them into *beldi* olives herself as she always did; yet after one month of trying via various sources, she gave up, and we bought several kilograms of “normal” (*adi*) preserved olives in a shop. Of course, the price of olives had nearly doubled in the meantime, thwarting Fatimzahra’s efforts to save money by provisioning them via her relatives.

When I later asked her to explain the situation to me, she replied, “It was the Americans’ fault.” From one of her acquaintances near the city of Beni Mellal, an olive producer, she found out that American buyers had come to Morocco to buy unprocessed olives, because “abroad” the harvest had not been good that year.<sup>9</sup> She mentioned that fresh Moroccan produce fetched a higher price when sold abroad and that, to make matters worse, this also drove up domestic prices. Whereas Hajja lauded the technological changes that eased some of her daily workload and seemed resigned to watching the world globalize, Fatimzahra was angered by what she described as a “sell-out” of Moroccan food products to wealthier foreigners like myself. She tirelessly pointed this out to me whenever her work to identify and make *beldi* foods bore no fruits.

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Fatimzahra's failure to find and make *beldi* olives further showcases the work invested in making *beldi* foods and relates it to broader social, material, and environmental changes in Morocco. Especially from the perspective of younger low-income Moroccans, the work to make *beldi* foods is symptomatic of a degrading economy and environment (see also Demossier, this volume). These developments are real and the result of a historically dualist approach to agriculture. Since at least the times of the French Protectorate (1912–56) and cemented in the 2008 Green Morocco Plan (GMP), the Moroccan government has favored the industrial production of resource-intensive cash crops for export over more environmentally adapted smallholder farming for the domestic market (Swearingen 1987; Akesbi 2014). Given the potential that origin labeling has for political control and economic extraction (as Caldwell shows in the case of Russia, this volume), it is not surprising that a major aim of the GMP is the implementation of GIs across a wide range of modernized and resource-intensive commodities, which contribute to the degradation of the Moroccan environment in favor of foreign currencies and to the detriment of national food security and food sovereignty (cf. Akesbi 2014). As a result, the Moroccan food market is well integrated into the global market, with a fast-growing range of standardized food products destined for export, while smaller producers and subsistence farmers like Hajja's family are marginalized and driven out of business (cf. Sippel 2014). As described above, when fruits and vegetables unfit for export are discarded and enter the unregulated domestic market, the latter serves as a shock absorber for the highly competitive global market (Boeckler and Berndt 2014), resulting in unpredictable availabilities, poor quality, and price deformations in the domestic market. In this context, *beldi* foods are increasingly hard to come by.

The vignette provides a glimpse of the difficulties that low-income Moroccans—rural and urban—face in provisioning, preparing, and consuming foods that are tasty, healthy, and meaningful to them. Low-income women like Fatimzahra invest a lot of work in sourcing and preparing *beldi* foods, yet in the ever-more globalized Moroccan market context, they grow increasingly frustrated at their inability to do so. In combination with the previous vignettes, this last vignette highlights how deeply low-income Moroccans care about placing and tasting foods and how difficult this work is becoming. Fatimzahra's problems in sourcing and processing olives into *beldi* olives are not only about reconnecting her and her family back to their *bled*, tethering them to their origins in the agricultural countryside, nor are they only about recreating a taste of their past in the present and for the future, but they also express more existential difficulties of living well and exerting agency and control in the context of globalized poverty. For poverty is not simply the absence of money but also of water and land, and of social relations; a truly poor person is one without *'asl* (roots, origin). Not

being able to make and eat *beldi* foods is thus both a bodily felt sense of loss of control and a daily reminder of one's marginal, seemingly forgotten position in an unequally globalized world.

## Conclusion

Hajja's suitcase full of *beldi* and non-*beldi* foods on the way to Mecca at once materializes and symbolizes the importance of placing and tasting foods for low-income Moroccans like her. She packed her life and everything it symbolized, where she is coming from, who she is, and where she might be going. At the very least, the recounting of Hajja's and Fatimzahra's taste of place demonstrates that understanding the materially and socially constructed connections between food, place, and taste requires attending to peoples' and foods' movements over space and time (and many more actors, see for instance Pope and West, this volume). Of course, it is impossible to describe the many social, material, and environmental changes that mark the lives of Hajja and Fatimzahra in the space of one chapter. Yet, each vignette provided snapshots of the shifting connections between people and their meaningful practices of tasting and placing foods and people.

All the vignettes highlight the breadth of the largely invisible work that domestic cooks and urban consumers do to make foods *beldi* and thus good for them; seemingly small practices like packing and transporting homegrown and home-preserved lemons to faraway places, making and drinking *ghaib*, or sourcing and processing a few kilograms of *beldi* olives. The first vignette about *beldi* lemons highlighted how *beldi* could be dubbed "my taste of place": an embodied and intimate marker of food quality, which still serves as widely shared index for placing people and products across Morocco, particularly in contexts of migration and movement. The next vignette about processing raw milk demonstrated that through the knowledgeable work of provisioning and making *beldi* foods, domestic cooks gain a sense of control in a highly uncontrollable and volatile market context and life more generally. The last vignette, on trying and failing to provision olives, embeds the work of placing and tasting foods in the broader context of globalization and poverty. Taken together, the vignettes demonstrate not only how sourcing and making *beldi* foods is an intimate bodily practice but also how the work of maintaining relations, knowledge, and taste of and for these foods is also constrained by problematic agricultural policies that favor export production over domestic food sovereignty. And, of course, these two things are also closely connected.

Ultimately, *beldi* as told through Hajja and Fatimzahra is a story of gradual decline and of loss, evoking common themes across a world marked by migration, environmental degradation, repeated financial crises, and rising levels of poverty.

At the same time, this chapter reminds us that the persistence of the concept of *beldi* and of *beldi* foods today is also owed to the knowledge and continuous work of women like Hajja and Fatimzahra who, in making *beldi* foods against the odds, reproduce not only the taste and place of foods that matter to them but also themselves and other disenfranchised people in this context. In other words, to understand the past, present, and future of people and their places and tastes “beyond terroir,” it is worth attending to less visible actors such as domestic cooks and their everyday work to make good food in an increasingly unequal world.

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## Notes

1. All names used in this chapter are real names, in accordance with interlocutors' consent.
2. Dying during the hajj is considered an honorable death for elderly Muslims. Although Hajja was in her mid-sixties, no one in her family expected her to die during the journey. Yet, symbolically, all family members parted from her as if they were seeing her for the last time. Her safe return, one month later, was thus celebrated accordingly.
3. The Moroccan government has actively encouraged the production of geographical indication (GI) products since the early 2000s (Lambarraa-Lehnhardt, Ihle, and Elyoubi 2021).
4. I have known the family since 2007 when Fatimzahra taught me *darija*, the Moroccan Arabic dialect.
5. In 2019 Hajja sold the near-crumbling *riad* to a European neighbor and, together with Fatimzahra, bought a small purpose-built apartment near Hassan's flat.
6. He was the only person I asked about *beldi* foods who defined its broad characteristics abstractly. All other interview partners related to *beldi* from their own embodied perspective and emplaced positionality.

7. If considering *beldi* exclusively from a rural perspective, it is less surprising why it might be described as a terroir-like concept. Simenel (2010) even argues that rural Moroccans accord more value to their terroir than rural societies in France. However, as soon as a person or foods travel (including the ethnographer), the notion of terroir quickly loses its analytical capacity to explain relations between people, foods taste, and place in Morocco.
8. Associations of taste with class are commonplace across class-divided societies. Based on Bourdieu's notion of class distinction in French society, Wilk (1999) provides a useful comparative perspective on how tastes for certain foods—for example, lobster—were linked to colonial-era class identities in Belize.
9. Indeed, see Butler 2013.

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